WHILE *SATLUJ* DEPICTS KHALRA'S TRIAL ACCURATELY, IT OMITS MENTION OF HIS HARD-LINE POLITICS AND THE VIOLENCE UNLEASHED BY THE TERRORISTS WHOSE SIDE HE STOOD ON

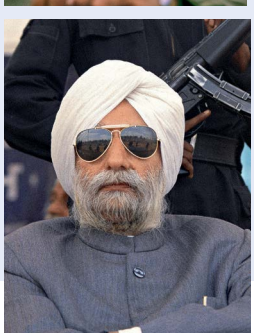
media. In fact, Punjab Police, which in time drew the support of significant numbers of central paramilitary personnel, remained the only functioning arm of the state government. A persistent sense of fear and foreboding engulfed the Punjabi hinterland, particularly in the border districts, where armed Khalistani gangs ruled and went virtually unchallenged after sunset. Most roads, including usually busy highways like the Grand Trunk Road, were deserted; the odd vehicle that still ventured out was invariably either a heavily armed police party or a tractor-trolley carting trigger-happy terrorists, many of them still in their teens. Punjab, quite literally, was ruled by the Kalashnikov.

Long before the Taliban, Khalistani groups were already using guns to enforce social diktats—schools barred from teaching Hindi or singing the national anthem, girls forced to wear salwar-kameez with saffron dupattas instead of skirts. In December 1990, Nirmal Kanta, principal of a senior secondary school in NTC, Rajpura, was shot dead in the school grounds for defying orders. Jeans and make-up invited similar reprisal on the streets.

Men were not spared either: those with shorn hair or trimmed beards were punished in public. On August 17, 1986, in village Dhattal near Amritsar, powerloom worker Baldev Singh, 30, and a co-worker were accosted by armed men, who objected to their haircuts—the gunmen killed his friend and left Singh permanently crippled with bullets in his throat and spine. To allow terrorists to move undetected after dark, villagers were forbidden from keeping dogs and ordered to cull strays—non-compliance could, and sometimes did, mean death. Some diktats were bizarre: Sikh couples were told to avoid contraception, to ensure







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HEART OF DARKNESS: Clockwise from left, soldiers outside Golden Temple during Op. Bluestar; former Punjab DGP K.P.S. Gill; ex-CM Beant Singh; militants in the temple during Op. Black Thunder, 1988

round the complex, cut off supplies and use snipers to force militants to surrender

1988-1993: Terrorists create a climate in which magistrates become afraid to hear terrorism cases. Babbar Khalsa bombs explode in courts at Gurdaspur, Hoshiarpur and Patiala, killing 13. In the next five years, 12 judicial officers are assassinated. Judge Hans Raj Kaushik is shot dead inside his courtroom in Moga

JULY 23, 1990: Militants assassinate chief engineer M.S. Sekhri and superintending engineer Avtar Singh Aulakh of Bhakra Beas Management Board. Their aim? To halt the construction of the Sutlej–Yamuna Link Canal

1991-92: Violence peaks, 5,265 civilians, security personnel and militants are killed. On Jun. 15, KLF gunmen attack two passenger trains near Ludhiana, at Kila Raipur and Baddowal, killing 110

↘ Militants also start killing kin of police personnel to force them to resign. In 1991, 134 relatives of cops are murdered; another 200+ the following year

↘ Militants declare boycott of the 1991 assembly polls, targeting candidates and campaign workers. Over 700 people, including 24 Akali candidates, are killed, forcing polls to be countermanded

1992-94: K.P.S. Gill returns as Punjab DGP in 1991 and ensures peaceful conduct of Feb. 1992 election that brings Beant Singh-led Congress to power. Gill rebuilds police morale, rewards officers who take the fight to the militants and launches Operation Night Dominance to reclaim rural areas

↘ Army units cordon villages while police teams use local intelligence and surrendered militants to identify hideouts and commanders. Major leaders—including Gurjant Singh Budhsinghwala and Sukhdev Singh Babbar—are eliminated; several militant organisations dismantled. By 1993, killings fall sharply; by 1994, only two civilians are killed in terrorist attacks, with no security force fatalities

1995: Human-rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalra exposes illegal detention, torture, staged encounters and enforced disappearances by police. On Aug. 31, a Khalistani suicide bomber assassinates Beant Singh. Six days later, Khalra is abducted from outside his Amritsar home, then tortured and killed in police custody; his body thrown into the Sutlej. Eight police officers get sentenced to life imprisonment for his murder